

The Gadget Generation

From wearables and audio to smart homes and wellness tech, Gen Z now drives almost 50% of India's \$45–50 billion consumer tech market

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THEY ARE called Gen Z, but in India's fast-evolving consumer economy, a more accurate label may perhaps be the *gadget generation*. This is a cohort that splurges willingly on travel, concerts and experiences, yet an equally significant share of its discretionary spending is channelled to technology. And no, it isn't just smartphones.

From gaming consoles and audio wearables to healthtech devices, personalised accessories and smart home products, Gen Z's relationship with gadgets is expansive and deeply personal. Technology, for them, is not just functional, it is immersive, expressive and constantly connected. What matters just as much is whether a product aligns with their values: sustainability, authenticity, brand purpose and,

crucially, social validation. For a generation raised on Instagram reels, YouTube reviews and creator-led discovery, a gadget is as much a lifestyle signal as it is a utility.

The numbers show why brands are scrambling for relevance. According to reports, of India's \$45–50 billion consumer tech devices market, almost half or nearly \$20–25 billion is driven by Gen Z, or Zoomers. At an estimated 377 million people today, Zoomers already are the largest generation India has seen. Born into an internet-connected economy where digital consumption was inevitable, technology is the backbone of their lives.

Smartphones continue to anchor this ecosystem. According to the BT-PRICE Gen Z Consumption Behaviour Survey, smartphones are at the centre of their digital life, and device choice clearly reflects income, education and aspira-

tion levels. The iPhone dominates smartphone usage in this cohort at 31%, with penetration rising sharply among metro users, post-graduates and those with higher incomes. Usage jumps from 10% in those who earn less than ₹2 lakh to nearly 80% among those earning over ₹15 lakh.

At 23%, Samsung remains the strongest mass-market rival across income groups, while Chinese brands like Vivo, Xiaomi and Oppo resonate with lower-income and Tier II consumers. Despite premium momentum, the ₹25,000–50,000 mid-premium band remains the most popular.

However, spending is also increasingly spilling over into adjacent categories. Wearables, audio devices, wellness gadgets, gaming hardware and smart appliances are finding greater acceptance among young buyers who view technology as an extension of their lifestyle